

Research Statement

Qilin Zhang

I am a macroeconomist who studies topics in public and family economics. I use microdata and quantitative models to study how households respond to institutions and public policy. China is the main setting for my research because its demographic and institutional changes raise direct questions about family decisions, public investment, and long-run economic outcomes. My current work focuses on marriage, parental investment, and the allocation of resources across generations. I also study local government debt and public finance.

My primary research project studies the decline in marriage in China. I ask how changes in the economic returns to marriage and in the cost of raising children affect marriage decisions, parental investment, and saving. I combine household survey data with a quantitative model of marriage and family formation. Individuals differ in characteristics that matter for matching and make forward-looking decisions about education investment, marriage, and assets. The model helps separate the roles of preferences, economic conditions, and policy-relevant costs.

Marriage, parental investment, and household decisions

The empirical part of the project documents several related changes in China. Marriage has become less common, while resources devoted to children and the economic gap between potential partners have changed across cohorts and places. Using household survey data, I document that the marriage market is assortative and that parents' investment mix differs by child gender. These patterns suggest that marriage-market outcomes are linked to household investment decisions. Parents choose how much to invest in children before those children enter the marriage market, and those investments can affect later matching outcomes. Expected marriage and childbearing decisions also shape saving and education choices.

The quantitative model formalizes these links. Individuals enter the marriage market with different levels of education, resources, and family background. They match in a frictional market, form households, and make decisions about children and assets. Parents value their children's outcomes but face the direct cost of education as well as the opportunity cost of time and resources. The dynastic structure connects parental investment to both household behavior and aggregate demographic outcomes.

I use the model to study policy counterfactuals. Removing the gender gap in the cost of education raises the marriage rate by 1.85 percentage points. As parents grow richer with China's growth, the model explains 35 percent of the fall in the crude marriage rate between 2010 and 2024 and predicts a further decline. The effects of transfers also depend on their recipients: subsidies to newlyweds raise marriage, whereas equal-sized transfers to parents lower it. These results show how policies that change investment costs or household resources can affect marriage decisions and the distribution of investment across children and families.

The project treats marriage matching and parental investment as joint decisions rather than separate margins. It also connects individual behavior to aggregate demographic trends in a quantitative framework. The empirical patterns discipline the mechanisms used in the model and the counterfactual analysis gives them a direct policy interpretation.

Public finance and local government debt

My second project is a solo-authored paper, "A Micro Anatomy of the Hidden Local Government Debt in China: 2014–2023," presented at the 2025 Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting. The paper introduces a newly constructed dataset containing firm-level and city-level information on 2,940 industrial local government financing vehicles across 305 cities, compiled from public disclosures. The project is motivated by a basic public finance question: when formal fiscal resources are limited, how do local governments finance

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investment, and what are the consequences for the allocation of resources? The paper documents heterogeneity in hidden debt exposure across regions and sectors. It places local government debt in an institutional setting in which local governments have important responsibilities for investment and development but face constraints on ordinary-budget revenue. The dataset supports future work on the geography of off-balance-sheet debt, fiscal transparency, and debt sustainability.

Ongoing and future research

In “Mass Layoffs and Fertility: Evidence from WARN-Based Shocks,” joint with Yuchen Zhu, I study how local labor-market shocks affect fertility. Using WARN mass-layoff notices linked to county-level natality data from 2020 to 2024, we examine how the timing and intensity of layoffs relate to subsequent fertility. Preliminary results suggest that larger layoff shocks are followed by higher fertility, with the response emerging about ten months after the shock and concentrated among large layoffs. Ongoing work examines the roles of the opportunity cost of time and maternal selection. In “Residential Mobility and Household Consumption,” joint with Yanqi Li, I study the relationship between residential mobility and household consumption using PSID data. Looking ahead, I am interested in how retirement expectations and intergenerational transfers shape saving and education investment, and in how regional fiscal conditions affect the cost and availability of education, housing, and family services.

Across these projects, I begin with detailed microdata and use quantitative models when they help distinguish mechanisms or evaluate policy counterfactuals. I am interested in questions that matter both for academic research and for the decisions faced by households and policymakers.